PURELIVINGZONE · FREE GUIDE

The Whey Guide

Seven things your grandmother did with whey that you pour down the drain every morning

WHAT WHEY IS AND ITS NUTRITIONAL VALUE

- Acid whey: from yogurt, kefir, or cultured dairy. Pale yellow, tangy. Rich in lactic acid, minerals (calcium, phosphorus, potassium), probiotics, and protein.
- Sweet whey: from cheese-making (rennet-set cheeses). Higher in protein, lactose, and B vitamins. Milder flavour.
- Both are valuable. Acid whey is what most home producers generate. Never pour it down the drain - it pollutes waterways (very high BOD) and wastes nutrition.

USE 1 - FERMENTATION STARTER

- Whey from active yogurt or kefir contains live lactobacillus cultures. Use it as a starter for your next batch of yogurt or kefir.
- Ratio: 2 tablespoons of whey per litre of warm milk (38-43°C). Stir, incubate 8-12 hours. Consistent results.
- Also works as a starter for lacto-fermented vegetables, pickles, and kvass. The live cultures acidify the brine and preserve the food.

USE 2 - BREAD LEAVENING & FLAVOUR

- Substitute whey for water in any bread recipe. The lactic acid interacts with gluten, producing a more tender crumb and mild tang.
- Works in sourdough, yeast breads, flatbreads, and pancakes. 1:1 substitution - replace water with whey.
- For sourdough: whey feeds the starter faster than plain water. Use it for your regular starter feeding.

USE 3 - LACTO-FERMENTING VEGETABLES

- Replace some of the salt in your vegetable fermentation brine with whey. The cultures immediately colonise the brine and begin acidification.
- Classic brine: 1 tablespoon salt + 2 tablespoons whey per 500ml water. Submerge vegetables, ferment at room temperature 3-5 days.
- Produces a faster, more reliable ferment than salt-only methods - particularly useful in cooler kitchens.

USE 4 - SOAKING GRAINS & LEGUMES

- Soak oats, rice, beans, or lentils in whey-water (50:50 with water) for 8-24 hours before cooking.
- The lactic acid breaks down phytic acid (an anti-nutrient that blocks mineral absorption) and partially pre-digests the starches.
- Result: better mineral absorption, shorter cooking time, improved digestibility. Traditional cultures did this automatically.

USES 5-7: WOUND WASH, GARDEN FERTILISER, ANIMAL FEED

- Topical wound wash: dilute whey 1:1 with clean water. The lactic acid creates a mildly acidic environment that is hostile to pathogenic bacteria. Used traditionally for minor cuts and skin irritations.
- Plant fertiliser: dilute whey 10:1 with water. Apply to root zone, not leaves. The minerals, protein, and beneficial microbes

feed soil biology. Especially good for heavy-feeding vegetables.

- Animal feed: chickens, pigs, and dogs love whey. Chickens respond with improved egg production. For pigs, it was the traditional supplement on every homestead dairy farm. No dilution needed - pour it into the feed or a trough directly.

STORAGE & TROUBLESHOOTING

- Refrigerated: whey keeps 6 months in the fridge in a sealed jar. It may become more sour over time - still usable.
- Frozen: freeze in ice cube trays, transfer to a bag. Use within 6 months. Thaw overnight in the fridge.
- Separation: whey stored for a while may separate into a cloudy layer and a clear layer. Normal. Shake before use.
- What whey cannot substitute: acid whey is too thin and sour for most cream-based recipes. It is not a cream or milk substitute.

>> THE SAGE'S TIP: Keep a 1-litre jar in the fridge labelled WHEY. Add to it every time you strain yogurt. Use it in bread, soaking water, or the garden within a week. Nothing is wasted.

The liquid your grandmother poured into the garden fed the soil that fed your family. Stop pouring it down the drain. - The Sage